

Mishandling Floods

Floods occur and cause heavy damage to life and property. Such catastrophes require a great deal of national enthusiasm to cope with, where the state machinery leads from the front. This is not so in our case, for the state machinery here in Pakistan fails on all occasions. It failed during the floods of 2010 and 2012. It has failed even today to handle the ongoing floods across the country. The 'control rooms' and the 'war rooms' are not going to rescue the flood affected people in practical terms. It is too late to rescue the victims, for the ongoing catastrophe has cost much regarding life and property. The concerned authority had an idea about the quantity and duration of the rain spell, and that it had information through a revolutionized meteorological department. It could have responded quickly. It could have deployed the rescue teams earlier. It could have gathered boats, tents and ration in time. Above all, it could have shifted the people to the safe places a little earlier, but it did not. Only the volunteers of various organizations responded first. Their efforts are appreciable indeed. But, how long will they continue to serve? The matter is not of few square kilometers, but of the tens of thousands of kilometers across the country. The people are in a desperate situation all around. The injuries of the people are too deep to be cured, and that the graph of destruction looks in the upward trajectory yet.

The death toll has surpassed the figure of 1400 according to an international news agency. The families cut off in the mountains of Baluchistan; the individuals caught in the areas of Kaccha in Sindh and Punjab, and the victims encapsulated in the steep valleys of KPK, are hardly being contacted. The demolition of houses due to torrential rains and flashfloods is still continuing and seems to be continued further. According to a foreign news agency, more than 0.6 million houses have been demolished since mid of June. The muddy houses of the countryside are highly vulnerable to collapsed aimed flashfloods. In this connection, the remaining houses are going to be dashed to ground in the days ahead. Properties of the flood affected people have been washed away forever. The survivors have lost their means of living with their loved ones. The moment they are getting free from the ongoing uncertainty, life is becoming tougher for them. On the health part, they are facing skin related and other deadly diseases. The ramification of the said calamity does not stop here. It is going to last a little longer, because the way the public and private organizations are rescuing the flood effectees is not going to earn the victims money. Firstly, the people surviving in a desperate situation amid floods are looting the trucks and carriers fearing that they may not get their due share. Secondly, the authorities and organizations are handing over trucks of ration to the nabobs and waderas of the area concerned where both the latter ones are stocking the relief goods in their godouns. Only the photo session is being done across the flood hit areas.

We the people may appreciate the ongoing rescue activities of all the public and non-public organizations, but we cannot deny their incompetency to respond to the natural calamity quickly, and that fair distribution of relief to the flood victims all around. Had the authorities concerned responded earlier and shown competency on the part of relief activities, the graph of destruction would have not risen up, and that the people might not fall prey to uncertainty amid relief activities.

The contemporary nations of Pakistan have managed the ongoing floods better comparatively. The flood in west China, during the second week of this August, cost only 16 lives. Last week's flood in South Korea took the lives of only four people. Japan also managed to cope with tsunamis on various occasions. The Japanese managed to reduce the intensity of destruction viz-a-viz life and property. The said nations somehow managed the equation of natural calamities. The question is when Pakistan will learn lessons from these examples. We did not learn even from the floods of 2010 and 2012. In the words of **G. B. Saw**, ***"We learn from history that we learn nothing from history."***

The issue behind this sorry state is lack of sensible leadership in the country. The politicians have been and are still busy in the war of occupying the throne. The incumbent government could have stepped down aimed at its rising unpopularity. The opposition could have canceled its political power shows and deployed its abundant youth force in the rescue operations all around. The guardians could have convinced the political warlords in favor of the drowning people across the country. But, the said stakeholders did nothing.

It is high time for the state and society to take the lead and to cope with the continued natural disaster with great enthusiasm. The state authorities should take it as a wakeup call for the future. It should not ignore the current havoc further. Instead, it should come up with a sound responding system. It should prove the so-called 'control rooms' and 'war rooms' productive. The NDMA, PDMA, and the institutions involved should play their vital role in the rescue operations. Volunteer organizations should be encouraged and given support on their human centric services. The ill-treatment of deserving people in the hands of elites of the areas concerned should be checked in toto. The relief activities must not be on paper. Instead it must be on the ground. Then, it will be possible to come out of the ongoing catastrophe.

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Published in 2022 (Daily Times Pakistan)